

SOUTHEAST EUROPE

MUCH OF SOUTHEAST EUROPE consists of rugged mountains separated by deep river valleys. The area was called the Balkans, meaning “mountains” by the Turks, who ruled this area for 500 years until the early part of the 20th century. From 1918 until 1991, all these states, together with Croatia and Slovenia, were part of the newly created Yugoslavia; only Albania remained independent. After the fall of communism in Europe, age-old rivalries began to emerge. This led to the collapse of Yugoslavia and a vicious war that lasted from 1991—99. Kosovo is the latest country to declare independence, however its statehood is not universally recognised yet.



CROSSROADS OF CULTURE

History has placed this area at the crossroads of many different empires and each has left its influence on the language, customs, and religions of the people. Here, in the Bosnian city of Mostar, church spires belonging to Orthodox Christian and Roman Catholic churches mingle with the mosque minarets of Islam, the religion introduced by the Turks in the 15th century. Today new cultural landscapes are being created as groups try to re establish their national identity.

